were a strong lobby. They considered the standalone status of CSN as a drawback. The vast majority of the stakeholders favoured the Tatas. *The Times* (London) wrote that ‘a poisonous combination of high indebtedness and pension fund deficits’ in the case of CSN made the trade unions favour Tata Steel.

In India, however, the Tata Steel shareholders became nervous. The company’s share price had already witnessed a freefall since Ratan had announced his interest to acquire Corus. It fell a further 6 per cent in trade in Mumbai after the announcement.

Ratan had hoped that CSN would not be able to match the new price offered by Tata Steel. ‘We remain convinced of the compelling strategic rationale of this partnership and the revised terms deliver substantial additional value to Corus shareholders,’ he said at a press release. But he was mistaken.

No sooner had Tata Steel’s offer reached Corus than Steinbruch reached out to Leng and informed him that his company would soon be making a revised offer. His bankers and advisers worked into the night and before the crack of dawn on Monday, 11 December, CSN revised its bid to 515 pence a share, aggregating to £4.9 billion ($9.6 billion). Ratan was taken by surprise by Steinbruch’s quick manoeuvring. Around 7.30 a.m., the Corus board reconvened and recommended CSN’s offer.

As both Tata Steel and CSN had made competitive offers, on 19 December, a day before the revised date of the shareholders’ EGM, Britain’s takeover watchdog, the UK Takeover Panel, stepped in. It announced that both parties would be given more opportunities to revise their offers. It set 30–31 January 2007 as the deadline for both companies to make their final offer. The panel also forewarned that if the competition continued close to the deadline, it would resort to auction and let the hammer decide the winner. But that did not unleash a renewed battle. Both Tata Steel and CSN waited for the other to make the first move.

With each passing day, the investors grew disconsolate. The shareholders feared that Ratan was overvaluing an inefficient business. The fight to make Tata Steel the fifth-largest steel producer in the world was simply because ‘issues of personal ego may be hard to overcome’, wrote the *Financial Times*. There were several reports that insinuated that Ratan had become clouded in his judgement. *The Independent* wrote, ‘We are witnessing a clash of ambitions and egos almost certain to end with one party or the